

Why Phantoma

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I built Phantoma because the games I keep coming back to aren't the ones with the best combat or the tightest progression loops – they're the ones with spaces that feel *lived in*. PlayStation Home, early WoW capital cities, Habbo, VRChat on a good night: places where the point was the people and the vibe, not the objective. Most modern games have forgotten how to be hangout spaces; everything is a battle pass, a ranked ladder, a grind. Phantoma is trying to be the opposite of that – a small, beautiful world where the reward for showing up is just being there. For this final build I narrowed that whole vision down to its most honest, playable core: one expressive character, one explorable city, and controls that feel good enough that wandering is its own reward.

What makes it unique is the seam where the **character pipeline** meets the **world**. The playable character isn't a stock mannequin – she's a Mixamo-rigged chibi retargeted onto Unity's humanoid system, so the idle has personality and the jog reads as *someone moving*, not a capsule sliding. I wrapped that in a custom third-person camera I wrote from scratch (a mouse/stick orbit rig feeding Cinemachine), camera-relative movement with a sprint that actually costs something, and a Kingdom-Hearts-style arc HUD where the stamina ring drains as you sprint and recovers when you don't. None of those systems are bolted-on templates – they're ~680 lines of my own C#, including an editor tool that auto-imports and in-place-bakes any walk/run/jog animation I drop in, so the locomotion pipeline keeps moving as fast as I can find clips. That tooling mindset – building the thing that builds the game – is the part I'm proudest of.

And it's *cool* because of how it all comes together in the deep-purple light. The city is low-poly but it's lit like it matters: a warm key, a cool fill, a purple rim that follows the character through the streets, ACES tonemapping and bloom making the whole thing glow. You press Enter on a glowing title screen, drop onto a street, and the camera settles in behind a tiny character in a huge, quiet, colorful city – and the first thing almost everyone does is

just walk somewhere to see what's there. That instinct, "I want to go look at that," is the entire game working exactly as intended. The landmarks reward it with little fragments of the world's story, and nothing ever pushes you toward a score. It's a small slice, but it's a real one – and it's the truest version of Phantoma I've shipped so far.

Enhanced from the Phase 1 draft: rewritten to describe the actual shipped build – the chibi character, the lit city, the custom camera/HUD/animation systems, and the deep-purple aesthetic.